





Clockwise from above: The Tatra Mountains rise above Zakopane; Chapel of Our Lady of the Rosary on Gubałówka, reached by funicular from Zakopane; Oscypek, the region's traditional smoked sheep's-milk cheese

ZAKOPANE, MOUNTAIN AIR

The drive from Krakow to Zakopane takes about two hours, long enough for the city to thin out and the terrain to rise towards the Tatras. Krupowki Street is the town's busiest commercial thoroughfare. Stores selling woollen rugs and carved wooden objects line the street, alongside cafes and restaurants. The most recognisable dish is oscypek, a firm smoked sheep's-milk cheese, often served grilled with cranberry sauce. Other staples include kwasnica, a sour soup made from fermented cabbage and meat, and pierogi filled with potato and cheese.

Step away from Krupowki, and a calmer side of Zakopane reveals itself. Wooden buildings with steep, shingled roofs, detailed carved decorations (often with floral motifs and geometric shapes), and stone foundations reflect a regional architecture influenced by climate, craftsmanship, and landscape. This unique style became known as the Zakopane Style, developed in the late nineteenth century by the artist and architect Stanislaw Witkiewicz. Its principles are showcased at the Museum of the Zakopane Style, located in Villa Koliba, the first building constructed in this manner.

Ride the Gubalowka funicular to enjoy expansive views of the Tatra Mountains, the highest range within the Carpathians. From Zakopane, marked hiking routes lead into the mountains for walkers of all levels. I chose the White Stream Valley Trail, an easy, well-maintained route that begins near town and follows a clear mountain stream through spruce forests and limestone outcrops. The path rises gradually, cool and shaded. Within minutes, the buzz of Zakopane fades away, and the Tatras feel close, immediate, and generous.